

IT'S RAINING MEN

Over the past decade or so, the men's team has been overshadowed largely by two wonder women—Saina Nehwal and P.V. Sindhu. Nehwal won India its first Olympic medal in the sport, with Sindhu adding two more, besides becoming the only Indian to win the World Championships. The women's team had already won two Uber Cup bronze medals (in 2014 and 2016), thanks to the doubles pair of Jwala Gutta and Ashwini Ponappa. Among the men, Srikanth had a stellar showing in 2017, winning four tournaments and even ascending to world No. 1 before hitting a slump that lasted three years and culminated in his failure to qualify for the 2020 Tokyo Olympics. The past six months have seen a renaissance in men's badminton with Sen's rise in the senior circuit. The 20-year-old has been on a dream run, grabbing the bronze at the 2021 World Championships, winning the men's singles title at the India Open 2022 and finishing runner-up at the All England Open Badminton Championships. It coincided with Srikanth going back to his winning ways after finishing second at the 2021 World Championships. Prannoy was a finalist at the 2022 Swiss Open.

India currently has 14 players in the top 100 of men's singles. And now it finally has a top-notch doubles pair in Shetty and Rankireddy, ranked eighth in the world. They are not alone. Dhruv Kapila and Arjun along with Krishna Prasad and Vishnuvardhan are the next generation of doubles pairs to watch out for. It has meant that the burden isn't on singles specialists as has historically been the case in the competition. Vimal Kumar credits the Indian Badminton League for the growth as it gives players the opportunity to mix with some of the best in the world. "One thing I noticed was whether it was the Danes or the English and the Malays, all of them were asking me, 'Are you going to have the league this year?' So, what we have started, we have to invest little more money and run it properly," says Kumar.

This abundance of talent is a huge asset and instrumental in the men's team lifting the silver trophy. "Not many countries can boast of that," said Gopichand. "It is a coming together of the players at the right time. I hope it happens more often in future." Himanta Biswa Sarma, president of the Badminton Association of India (BAI), is convinced that the victory will inspire youngsters to pick up the sport. "Indian women players have already created milestones, but this all-round performance by the boys will inspire the next generation of players and also enhance the popularity of the sport in India. Each of these shuttlers and their journey will create a legacy for the game," he says.



THE ROAD AHEAD

In an interview with Rajdeep Sardesai for India Today TV, Gopichand and badminton legend Prakash Padukone spoke of how the number of entries at the junior-level events had sky-

others to know we are not here just to play, but to win."

The messages had the desired effect. "Bonding among players is the key to success. The victory is a result of team effort and self-belief," says Rankireddy, 21. The Thomas & Uber Cup, much like the Asian Games and the Sudirman Cup, the international badminton mixed team competition, comes with no prize money. Srikanth, the squad captain who won all his six matches, took special pride in the fact that the "win is for the country". "After we won, everyone said 'India won the Thomas Cup' and not one player. That's a very special feeling," he said at a press conference after the victory. The Indian contingent celebrated the victory at a restaurant and returned to their hotel rooms to dance as was the routine after every win in the knockout stages, said Shetty.